Find Your Way Around

THE FREEDAWM GUIDE



ONE PAGE, ONE IDEA:
CHEAT SHEETS FOR RECORDING, EDITING AND MIXING

FreeDAWm

Welcome to FreeDAWm

A free, open-source studio for recording, editing and mixing music, on the computer you already have.

FreeDAWm is a digital audio workstation. It runs on macOS, Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, and in a web browser.

You work in two main windows. The **Edit** window is the timeline, where you record, cut and arrange. The **Mix** window is the mixer, where you balance and shape the sound.

This guide is a binder of cheat sheets, not a manual to read from start to finish. Each page covers one idea, and most are a picture with labels.

Keep the page you need open beside FreeDAWm, or print it and pin it up.

HOW TO READ A SHEET

- The lettered dots on a picture match the lettered notes under it.
- Keys look like this: `Cmd` `S`. Hold the first, press the second.
- On Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, press `Ctrl` wherever a sheet says `Cmd`.
- Menu items are written as a path: Setup › Keyboard Shortcuts.

The pictures show **Midnight Groove**, the demo song that comes with FreeDAWm, so your screen can match the page while you follow along.

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SECTION 1

Getting Around

The two windows you will spend your time in, the four ways clips can move, and the keys worth learning first.

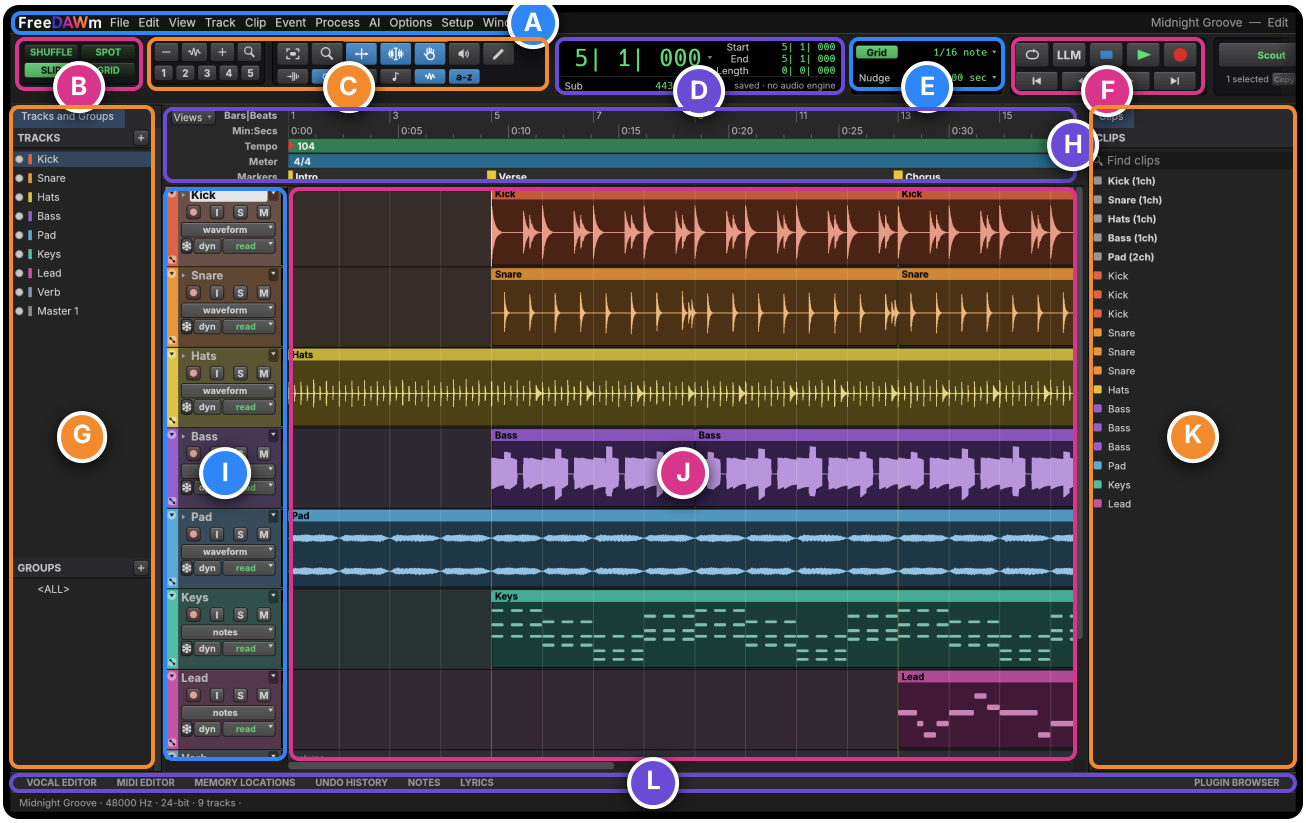
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THE EDIT WINDOW

The Goal

Know what each part of the timeline window is for, so you can find a control without hunting. Open it with Window › Edit, or press `Cmd` `=` to flip between Edit and Mix.



A — Menu bar
Every command lives here. If you forget a key, look in the menus.

B — Edit modes
Shuffle, Slip, Spot and Grid decide how clips move when you drag them. See page 7.

C — Zoom and tools
Zoom buttons and five zoom presets, then the editing tools. See page 7.

D — Counter
Where the cursor is, and the start, end and length of your selection.

E — Grid and Nudge
The size of a grid step and of a nudge. Nudge with `+` and `−`.

F — Transport
Loop, stop, play and record on top, and the buttons that jump or wind underneath.

G — Tracks and Groups
Every track in the song. Click the dot beside a name to show or hide that track.

H — Rulers
Time in bars and in minutes, then tempo, meter and markers.

I — Track controls
Record, input monitor (I), solo (S) and mute (M), then the track's view and automation mode.

J — Timeline
Your clips. Audio is drawn as waveforms and MIDI as notes. Time runs left to right.

K — Clips list
Every clip in the session. Type in Find clips to search it.

L — Panel tabs
Click a tab to open the Vocal Editor, MIDI Editor, Undo History and more.

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THE MIX WINDOW

The Goal

Read a channel strip from top to bottom. Sound enters at the top of a strip and leaves at the fader, so the order on screen is the order the sound travels.



A **Transport and counter**
The same play, stop and record controls as the Edit window.

B **Channel width**
Slim strips fit more on screen. Wide strips show each effect's knobs.

C **Effects**
EQ, compressors and the rest, processed from top to bottom. Click + to add one.

D **Sends**
Slots a to e each send a copy of the track somewhere else, often to a shared reverb.

E **I/O**
Where the track's sound comes from and goes to, then its automation mode.

F **Group and pan**
The knob places the sound left or right. Stereo tracks get one knob per side.

G **Strip buttons**
Input monitor, record and freeze, then solo (S) and mute (M).

H **Fader and meter**
The fader sets the track's level. The meter beside it shows how loud it is.

I **Level and name**
The fader's value in dB, the track type, and the track name.

J **Aux input**
Verb is an aux track. It takes whatever the other strips send to Verb.

Good to know

The list on the left is the same Tracks and Groups list as in the Edit window. The coloured bar under each name matches that track's clips on the timeline.

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EDIT MODES & TOOLS

The Goal

The edit mode decides where a clip lands when you move it. The tool decides what a click or drag does. Pick both before you edit.

THE FOUR EDIT MODES

BY HAND

Slip
F2 or Alt+2



Clips go exactly where you drop them. Gaps and overlaps are allowed. This is the mode FreeDAWm starts in.

Shuffle
F1 or Alt+1



Clips close up end to end. Cut a piece out and everything after it slides left to fill the gap.

STAYS WHERE YOU PUT IT

SNAPS INTO PLACE

Spot
F3 or Alt+3



FreeDAWm asks for an exact position, and the clip goes there. Use it when you know the time and not the place.

Grid
F4 or Alt+4



Clips and selections jump to the nearest grid line. Press F4 again for Relative Grid, which keeps a clip's offset from the line.

BY THE CLOCK

Left and right: does the clip stay where you put it, or does FreeDAWm line it up for you?

Up and down: do you place it by hand, or by a time on the ruler?

THE TOOLS

F5 Zoomer
Drag across an area to zoom in on it.

F6 Trim
Drag a clip's edge to make it shorter or longer.

F7 Selector
Click to place the cursor. Drag to select a range.

F8 Grabber
Drag a clip to move it.

F9 Scrubber
Drag over audio to hear it under the pointer.

F10 Pencil
Draw notes and automation.

Smart Tool

Press F6 and F7 together for three tools in one. Near a clip's edge it trims, in the upper half of a clip it selects, and in the lower half it grabs.

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KEYBOARD SHORTCUTS

The Goal

Learn these first. They cover most of a session, and each one saves a trip to the menus. On Windows, Linux and FreeBSD, press Ctrl wherever you see Cmd.

PLAY AND RECORD

Play or stop	Space
Record	F12 or Cmd Space
Play at half speed	Shift Space
Back to the start	Home
Go to the end	End
Add a marker	Enter
Loop playback on or off	Cmd Shift L
Play the selection	Alt [

TRACKS

New track	Cmd Shift N
Record enable	Shift R
Solo	Shift S
Mute	Shift M
Input monitoring	Shift I
Group tracks	Cmd G

SESSION

New session	Cmd N
Open a session	Cmd O
Save	Cmd S
Save as	Cmd Shift S
Import audio	Cmd Shift I
Bounce the mix to a file	Cmd Alt B

EDITING

Undo	Cmd Z
Redo	Cmd Shift Z
Cut, copy, paste	Cmd X C V
Duplicate	Cmd D
Select all	Cmd A
Split at the selection	Cmd E
Heal a split	Cmd H
Trim to the selection	Cmd T
Create fades	Cmd F
Mute a clip	Cmd M
Clear the selection	Cmd B or Delete
Nudge later or earlier	+ −

ZOOM AND VIEW

Zoom out or in	R T
Fit the whole session	Alt A
Zoom to the selection	Alt F
Zoom toggle	E
Jump to the next clip edge	Tab
Switch between Mix and Edit	Cmd =
Edit modes	F1 to F4
Tools	F5 to F10

Make them yours

Change any shortcut in Setup › Keyboard Shortcuts. A few keys are fixed, including Space, Enter, Tab and the F keys.

SECTION 2

Recording

Get sound into FreeDAWm: choose your audio device, make a track, record a take, and fix the part that went wrong without redoing the rest.

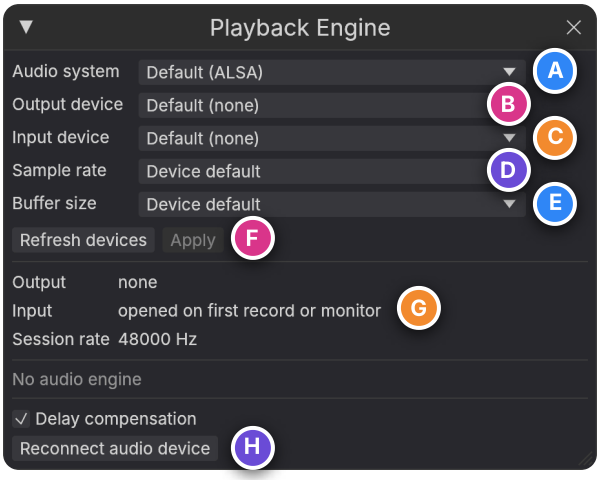
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SET UP YOUR SOUND

The Goal

Tell FreeDAWm which device to play through and record from. You do this once per device, in Setup › Playback Engine.



A — Audio system
How FreeDAWm talks to your sound hardware. Leave it on Default unless your interface needs another.

B — Output device
Where you hear the mix: your interface, speakers or headphones.

C — Input device
Where recordings come from: your interface or a microphone.

D — Sample rate
The detail of the sound. Device default is a safe choice.

E — Buffer size
How much sound is handled at a time. See below.

F — Refresh and Apply
Refresh after you plug something in. Apply makes your choices take effect.

G — Status
What is open right now, and the session's sample rate.

H — Reconnect
Click this if the sound stops after a device was unplugged.

BUFFER SIZE: A TRADE

SMALL — LARGE

Small buffer

You hear yourself with almost no delay, but the computer works harder and may crackle. Best while recording.

Large buffer

Steady playback with lots of effects, but a delay you can hear when you play or sing. Best while mixing.

Good to know

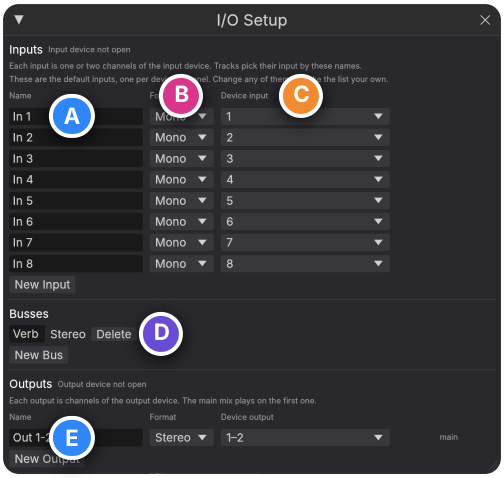
On the picture the input reads "opened on first record or monitor". FreeDAWm only opens your microphone when you arm a track or turn on monitoring.

FreeDAWm

INPUTS & NEW TRACKS

The Goal

Give your inputs names you will recognise, then make a track to record on. Named inputs save you from guessing which socket is which.



A **Input names**
Open Setup › I/O and type over a name: Vocal Mic, Guitar DI. Tracks pick their input by these names.

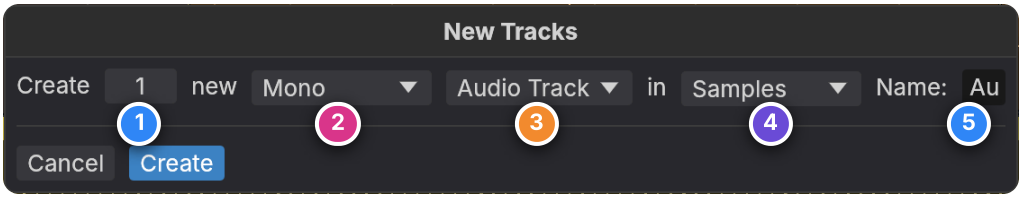
B **Format**
Mono is one channel, for a single mic or cable. Stereo is a pair.

C **Device input**
Which socket on your interface this name stands for.

D **Busses**
Paths inside FreeDAWm, used to send several tracks to one place.

E **Outputs**
Where sound leaves. The main mix plays on the first one.

MAKE A TRACK



Track › New, or Cmd Shift N

1 **How many**
Make several tracks in one go.

2 **Mono or stereo**
Match the input you will record.

3 **Track type**
See the table below.

4 **Samples or ticks**
Ticks make clips follow tempo changes.

5 **Name**
Name it now. Recordings take the track's name.

Audio Track	Records and plays sound: a voice, a guitar, a drum mic.
Instrument Track	Plays a software instrument from the notes you record or draw.
MIDI Track	Holds notes only, to drive an instrument somewhere else.
Aux Input	Has no clips. It takes sound from a bus, often for a shared reverb.
Master Fader	Controls the level of an output, usually the whole mix.

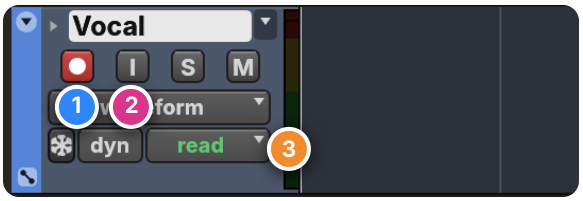
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RECORD A TAKE

The Goal

Record your first take in six steps. The first three happen on the track, the last three on the transport.

ON THE TRACK

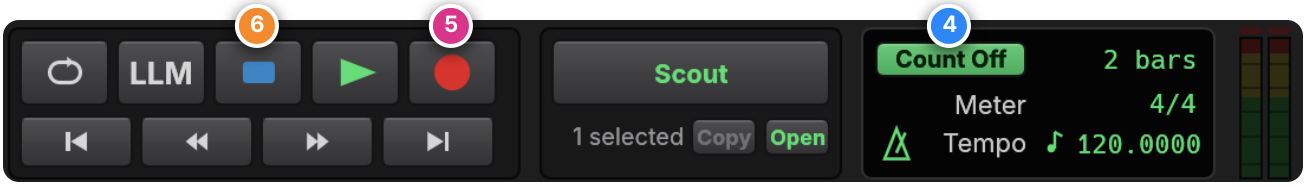


1 Arm the track
Click its record button so it lights red, or select the track and press Shift R.

2 Hear yourself
Click I to monitor the input through the track, effects included. Shift I does the same.

3 Check the level
Play or sing your loudest part and watch the meter. Turn the input down on your interface if it reaches the red at the top.

ON THE TRANSPORT



4 Count yourself in
Click Count Off to hear two bars of click before the take starts.

5 Record
Click the red button, or press F12 or Cmd Space.

6 Stop
Press Space. Your take appears as a clip on the track.

ALSO ON THE TRANSPORT

Metronome	The icon beside Tempo turns the click on or off during the take.
LLM	Low Latency Monitoring. It bypasses the effects that add delay on the tracks you are recording.
Loop	Plays the selection round and round. See the next page for recording in a loop.
Tempo and Meter	Set these before you record to a click. Drag the tempo, or click it to type a number.

Not happy?

Press Cmd Z to undo the take, then record again. FreeDAWm autosaves as you work and can recover a session after a crash.

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PUNCH, LOOP & COMP

The Goal

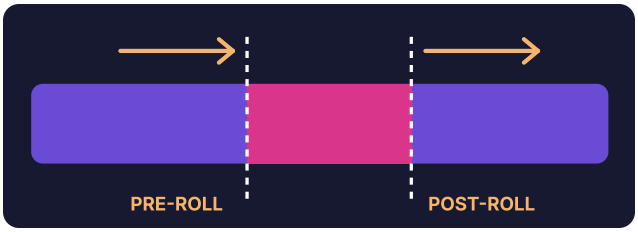
Fix one line without redoing the song, record several tries in a row, and build one good take from the best parts of each.



Punch in

Select the part you want to redo, then record. Only the selection is replaced. Everything around it stays.

No selection? Press Record while the song plays to drop in at that moment.



Pre-roll and post-roll

Turn on Options › Pre/Post-Roll, or press Cmd K. Playback starts a little before the punch so you can play along into it, and carries on a little after.



Loop record

Turn on Options › Loop Record, or press Alt L. Select the bars to repeat and record. Each time round makes a new take, so you can keep trying without stopping.



Comp the best parts

Click the small arrow before the track name to show its take layers. Drag across the part of a take you like and it is copied up into the track, with a short crossfade at each join.

SECTION 3

Editing

Shape what you recorded: cut and move clips, smooth the joins with fades, fix notes in the MIDI Editor, and find your way round a long song.

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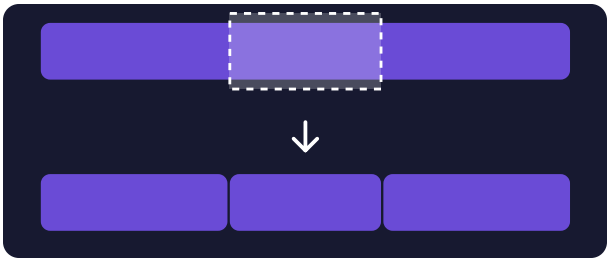
CUT, MOVE & TIDY

The Goal

Six edits do most of the work. Each one acts on the selection, so select first: drag across a clip with the Selector, or click once to place the cursor.

Split

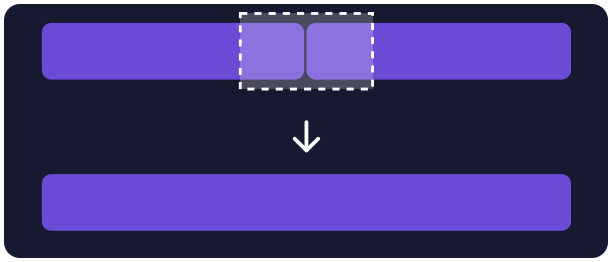
Cmd E



Cuts the clip at both edges of the selection. With only a cursor, it cuts once.

Heal

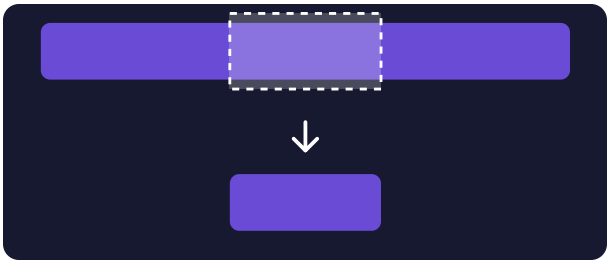
Cmd H



Select across a cut and heal it. The two pieces become one clip again.

Trim to selection

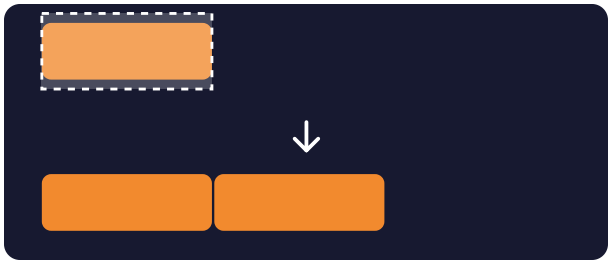
Cmd T



Keeps the selected part of the clip and removes the rest.

Duplicate

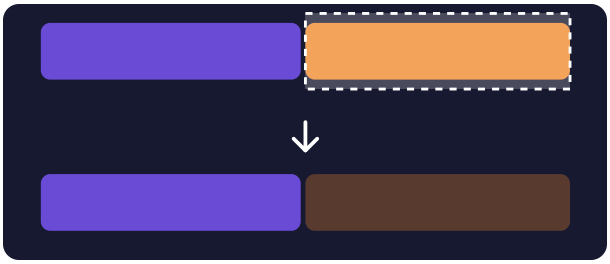
Cmd D



Places a copy straight after the selection. Press it again for another.

Mute

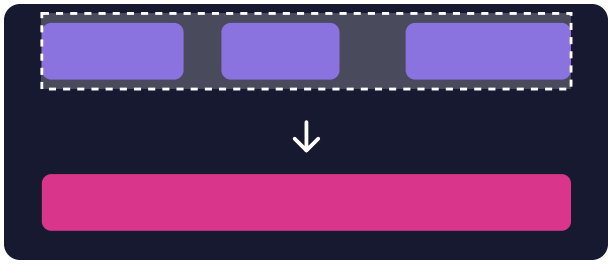
Cmd M



The clip stays where it is but makes no sound. Press again to bring it back.

Consolidate

Alt Shift 3



Turns the selection, gaps included, into one new clip.

Good to know

These edits change clips, not your recordings. To get trimmed sound back, drag the clip's edge out again with the Trim tool. Cmd Z undoes any of them.

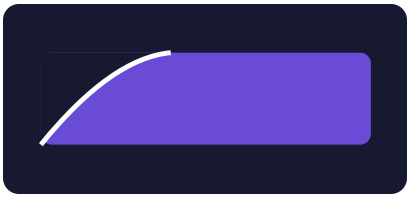
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FADES & CROSSFADES

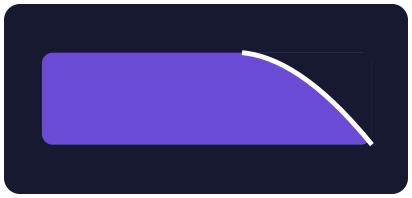
The Goal

A cut that lands in the middle of a sound can click. A fade ramps the level so the join is smooth. Put one on every edit you can hear.

THREE KINDS



Fade in
Select from before a clip's start to where the sound should be at full level.



Fade out
Select from where the fade should begin to past the clip's end.

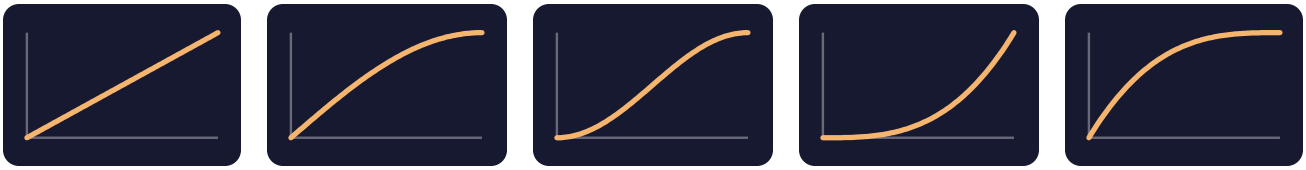


Crossfade
Select across the join between two clips. One fades out as the other fades in.

MAKE ONE

1. **Select**
   Drag across the start, the end or the join, as shown above.
2. **Create**
   Press Cmd F, or choose Edit › Fades › Create.
3. **Pick a shape**
   Choose one of the five below and click OK.

FIVE SHAPES



Linear
A straight ramp.

Equal Power
Keeps a crossfade's level steady. The usual choice.

S-Curve
Gentle at both ends.

Exponential
Starts slowly, then rises fast.

Logarithmic
Rises fast, then eases in.

Each curve shows the level of a fade in, from silence on the left to full on the right. A fade out is the mirror image.

Faster

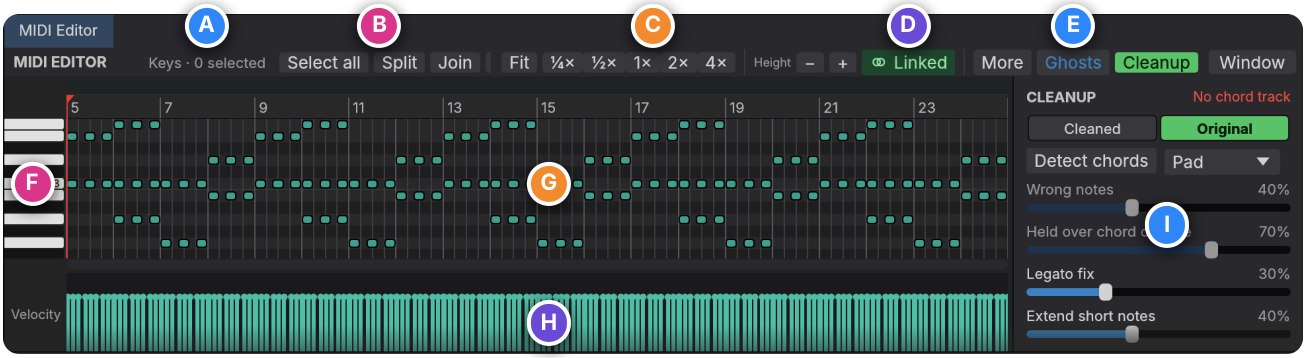
With the Smart Tool, drag from the top corner of a clip to draw a fade by hand. Edit › Fades › Delete removes the fades in the selection.

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THE MIDI EDITOR

The Goal

Fix and write notes. Select a MIDI clip and choose Window › MIDI Editor, or click the MIDI Editor tab at the bottom of the Edit window.



A **Clip and selection**
The clip you are editing and how many notes are selected.

B **Note tools**
Select all, Split at the playhead, and Join.

C **Zoom and height**
Fit shows the whole clip. ¼× to 4× zoom in time. Height makes the rows taller.

D **Linked**
Keeps the editor lined up with the Edit window's timeline.

E **Ghosts**
Shows the notes of other MIDI clips faintly, so you can write against them.

F **Piano keys**
Each row is one pitch. Click a key to hear it.

G **Notes**
Each bar is a note. Higher is higher in pitch, longer lasts longer. Drag to move one.

H **Velocity**
How hard each note is played. A taller bar is a louder note.

I **Cleanup**
Tidies a played part. Compare Cleaned with Original, then Commit.

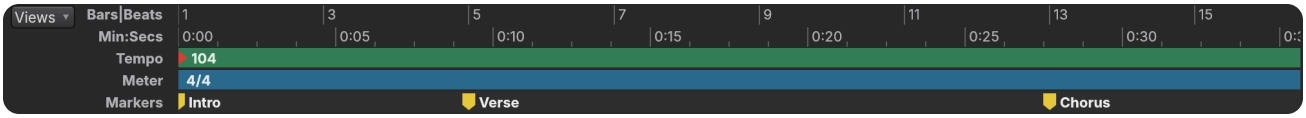
Play the selection	`Space` with the pointer over the notes
Move without snapping	Hold `Alt` while you drag
Cancel a drag	`Esc`
Fit the clip	`F` with the pointer over the notes
Quantize, Transpose	`Alt` `0`, `Alt` `T` (also in the Event menu)

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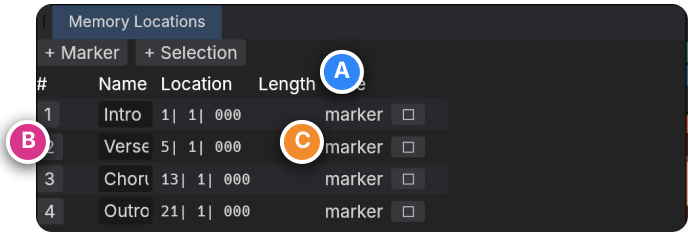
MARKERS & MOVING AROUND

The Goal

Label the parts of your song once, then jump between them. A few keys cover the rest: zooming, stepping from clip to clip, and nudging.



Markers show as flags on the Markers ruler, the bottom row here.



A **+ Marker and + Selection**
Marker stores the cursor's place. Selection stores the selected range. Enter also adds a marker.

B **Number**
Type . then the number then . to jump to that location.

C **Name and location**
What you called it and where it sits in the song.

Window › Memory Locations, or the Memory Locations tab at the bottom of the Edit window

ZOOM

Zoom out or in	R T
Fit the whole session	Alt A
Zoom to the selection	Alt F
Zoom toggle	E
Taller waveforms	Cmd Alt]
Recall a zoom preset	Click 1 to 5
Store a zoom preset	Cmd-click 1 to 5

MOVE AND NUDGE

Start or end of the session	Home End
Next clip edge	Tab
Previous clip edge	Alt Tab
Extend the selection as you go	Add Shift
Nudge later or earlier	+ −
Bigger or smaller grid	Shift = −
Bigger or smaller nudge	Alt Shift = −

Tab to Transient

Turn on Options › Tab to Transient and Tab stops at each hit inside a clip, not only at its edges. It is the quick way to find a drum hit to cut on.